

LIGHTER vs PACIFICA

Comparative Institutional Analysis

Perpetual Futures DEX Head-to-Head Evaluation

Report Date: November 30, 2025

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY:

For high size pro traders and serious market makers, **Lighter** is the better core venue today: more TVL and open interest on Ethereum, a formal insurance fund and forced exit design, at the cost of Stage 0 rollup governance and oracle risk.

For Solana native high turnover traders, **Pacifica** is a higher beta, local maximum: CEX-like UX, top Solana perp volumes, but much thinner TVL, hybrid off-chain engine, and opaque governance and multisig.

On 5 pillar scores, **Lighter leads 76/100 vs Pacifica 67/100**, mainly because of stronger market positioning and slightly better risk governance score, with team and tech essentially tied.

DISCLAIMER: This document is for informational and research purposes only. It does not constitute investment advice, financial advice, trading advice, or any other sort of advice. Token and incentive risk is high on both: there is no live token in either case, and both points systems map to hypothetical future tokens on terms that are not yet specified, so any airdrop expectation is speculative. Not investment advice, research only.

TLDR – LIGHTER vs PACIFICA

For high size pro traders and serious market makers:

Lighter is the better core venue today: more TVL and open interest on Ethereum, a formal insurance fund and forced exit design, at the cost of Stage 0 rollup governance and oracle risk.

For Solana native high turnover traders:

Pacifica is a higher beta, local maximum: CEX-like UX, top Solana perp volumes, but much thinner TVL, hybrid off-chain engine, and opaque governance and multisig.

On 5 pillar scores:

Lighter leads 76/100 vs Pacifica 67/100, mainly because of stronger market positioning and slightly better risk governance score, with team and tech essentially tied.

Token and incentive risk:

High on both: there is no live token in either case, and both points systems map to hypothetical future tokens on terms that are not yet specified, so any airdrop expectation is speculative.

Stance:

- **Lighter:** belongs in the "potential future core infra" bucket once token and decentralization are clarified.
- **Pacifica:** fits in a "watchlist, high beta Solana perps" bucket until it proves post-incentive stickiness and publishes more governance and contract detail.

1. COMBINED 5 PILLAR SCOREBOARD

Using the same 5 pillar structure and equal weighting used in the individual institutional reports.

Pillar	Lighter	Pacifica	Winner
Team and Execution	17 / 20	17 / 20	Tie
Technology, Security, Auditability	16 / 20	16 / 20	Tie
Tokenomics, Incentives, Liquidity	12 / 20	11 / 20	Lighter (slight)
Market Positioning, Narrative	18 / 20	12 / 20	Lighter (clear)
Risk Management, Governance	13 / 20	11 / 20	Lighter (modest)
COMPOSITE	76 / 100	67 / 100	Lighter

Conviction on these relative scores is medium. Both are early, both have meaningful governance and token unknowns, and both are still in points-driven reflexive regimes.

Pillar-by-Pillar Justification

Team and Execution (Tie – 17/17)

Both have very strong execution pedigrees and fast ship cycles. Lighter has a prodigy ex-Citadel founder with large tier-one VC backing; Pacifica has an ex-FTX COO plus deep CEX and TradFi bench but carries reputational overhang.

Technology, Security, Auditability (Tie – 16/16)

Lighter offers an Ethereum-settled zk rollup with forced exits and multiple audits; Pacifica offers a high-performance hybrid Solana architecture with BlockSec audit and a clear security story, but an off-chain matching engine and less disclosed code.

Tokenomics, Incentives, Liquidity (Slight edge Lighter – 12/11)

Both are pre-token and points-driven, but Lighter has clearer current revenue capture and a well-specified LLP structure; Pacifica has self-funded, no VC upside, but more contradictions and unknowns in points and future token design.

Market Positioning, Narrative (Clear edge Lighter – 18/12)

Lighter is already among the largest perp venues globally by 30-day notional and OI on Ethereum; Pacifica dominates Solana perps by share but is still smaller in absolute scale and more dependent on fee promos and Solana cycle strength.

Risk Management, Governance (Edge Lighter – 13/11)

Lighter has explicit forced exits, Ethereum data availability and an LLP insurance fund, yet suffers from Stage 0 instant upgrade and oracle verification risk. Pacifica uses Squads multisigs and hot-cold split but has undisclosed signers, upgradeable programs and a trusted off-chain engine.

2. PERSONA-LEVEL VERDICT MATRIX

Scores are 1 to 5 and are relative, not absolute.

User Persona	Lighter	Pacifica	Winner
High size pro trader (>\$100k)	4	3	Lighter
Points / airdrop farmer	4	3	Lighter (low conviction)
Casual degen, EVM native (<\$10k)	4	2	Lighter
Casual degen, Solana native (<\$10k)	2	4	Pacifica
Market maker / LP	4	3	Lighter

Detailed Reasoning by Persona

High Size Pro Trader (single ticket >\$100k)

Key priorities: Depth and OI, predictable liquidations, robust infra, low counterparty risk.

Winner: Lighter. Much higher TVL and OI on Ethereum, LLP insurance fund, forced exits and on-chain data availability are structurally better for size, despite Stage 0 governance risk and one recorded outage.

Pacifica has strong daily notional but far lower TVL and OI and relies on a trusted off-chain engine and Solana liveness. Confidence: medium.

Points and Airdrop Farmer

Key priorities: Short-term incentive yield per unit of capital, fee discounts, breadth of flow.

Winner: Lighter, low conviction. Both are pre-token with points, but Lighter runs a clear Season 2 program with documented weekly points allocations on top of zero-fee retail trading and very high fee revenue, which likely backs a larger eventual token pool. Pacifica points and future PACIFICA design are less clear and sources conflict on weekly emissions. This verdict would flip if Pacifica publishes a clean token and conversion design that is materially more generous.

Casual Degen, EVM Native (size <\$10k)

Key priorities: UX good enough, asset coverage, simple funding and access on Ethereum.

Winner: Lighter. EVM users can stay on Ethereum, get zero trading fees on retail UI, broad perp coverage including crypto and RWA, and do not need to bridge to Solana or learn a new wallet stack. Pacifica is viable but has extra friction and Solana dependency for this user. Confidence: high.

Casual Degen, Solana Native (size <\$10k)

Key priorities: CEX-like UX, fast fills, fits Solana wallet stack, meme and ecosystem pairs.

Winner: Pacifica. If your entire stack is Solana, Pacifica is currently the leading perp venue by Solana market share, with CEX-like latency and a UX that feels native to that ecosystem. Bridging to Ethereum just to trade Lighter is unlikely to be worth it at this size. Confidence: medium.

Market Maker or LP

Key priorities: Depth and flow quality, fee structure, counterparty model, API infra, risk.

Winner: Lighter. Ethereum settlement, very large 30-day notional and OI, and a documented LLP insurance structure make Lighter more attractive as a core venue for larger systematic MMs, despite centralised sequencer risk. Pacifica is interesting for Solana-specific strategy flow but has much thinner

TVL, unknown LP concentration and more opaque upgrade governance over the vaults. Confidence: medium.

In short: Lighter is the default institutional and EVM choice; Pacifica is the tactical Solana native choice.

3. KEY DELTAS BY DIMENSION

Mapping the five pillar reports onto more granular perp comparison dimensions and calling explicit winners where the evidence is strong enough.

3.1 Liquidity, Depth and Capital Structure

Lighter: About \$1.23B TVL, around \$1.7B open interest and roughly \$298B 30-day perp notional, plus an LLP that acts as insurance and risk buffer.

Pacifica: More than \$1B daily notional, OI around \$50–60M and TVL around \$40M, implying very high leverage and turnover relative to collateral, with explicit wash trade risk flagged.

Interpretation: Lighter clearly commands more absolute collateral and OI, which matters for very large clips and systemic MM strategies. Pacifica moves a lot of notional on much thinner capital, which is acceptable for smaller tickets but raises concern about how liquidity behaves in stress.

Verdict: Winner: Lighter, for true size trading and system MM. Confidence: medium.

3.2 Fees, Funding and PnL Realism

Lighter: Zero maker and taker fees for retail UI traders, with revenue coming from funding, liquidation fees and institutional/API trading fees. Funding and insurance flows go through the LLP.

Pacifica: Non-zero fees, roughly 0.015% maker and 0.04% taker, partially offset by fee promotions and points rewards, making the true net fee schedule state-dependent.

Verdict: For fee-sensitive retail, Winner: Lighter (high conviction). For sophisticated funding arb, no clear winner; insufficient data on funding deviations (low conviction).

3.3 Asset Coverage and Listing Quality

Lighter: Perps on majors like BTC, ETH, SOL plus RWA-style perps such as FX and gold, pitched as a cross-asset venue on Ethereum.

Pacifica: Positioned as leading Solana perps venue; focus is on Solana ecosystem assets rather than global RWA coverage.

Verdict: Winner for cross-asset and RWA: Lighter. Winner for Solana native names: Pacifica. Confidence: medium.

3.4 Risk Engine, Liquidations and Insurance

Lighter: Custom zk circuits encode matching, margin checks and liquidations; three margin tiers, partial then full liquidation, and an LLP that accrues liquidation fees and is designed to absorb losses, with external commentary that liquidations are gentler than some peers but oracle risk remains.

Pacifica: 50x leverage, cross and isolated margin, with Solana programs managing margin and custody; no detailed liquidation cascade description or explicit insurance fund mechanics beyond treasury and cold vault.

Verdict: Winner: Lighter (medium conviction). More explicit, audited risk engine plus a dedicated insurance construct, though complexity and oracle dependence raise their own risks.

3.5 Oracle Design and Latency

Lighter: Uses Stork as primary oracle for crypto perps and Chainlink Data Streams for RWA perps; L2Beat notes that external signatures are not fully verified on-chain yet and flags this as a key risk.

Pacifica: Likely uses Pyth or Switchboard, but the exact oracle set is not specified; docs only talk about reliance on "reliable price oracles."

Verdict: No strong winner. Lighter: more explicit design and known risks. Pacifica: less documented, which is itself a risk. Confidence: low.

3.6 Counterparty Model and Insolvency Risk

Lighter: Ethereum-settled zk rollup with all state data on-chain, forced L1 transactions and an LLP that is explicitly tasked with absorbing losses; however, critical upgrade risk exists because contracts are instantly upgradeable.

Pacifica: Users deposit USDC into Solana vaults, with custody structured via hot wallets and a Squads multisig cold vault; matching is off-chain; upgrade powers and signer details are not fully disclosed.

Verdict: Winner: Lighter (medium conviction). Explicit forced exit design and LLP insurance fund are strong positives even though upgrade risk is real. Pacifica relies more heavily on social trust.

3.7 Token Incentives, Emissions and Points

Lighter: No token live; Lighter Points accrue via trading, LPing and referrals, with 250k points per week through end of 2025. Strong market expectation of a LIGHT token and large revenue today, but no public supply or vesting detail.

Pacifica: No token live; Pacifica Points accrue via trading and fee promos; sources conflict between 500k and 10M weekly points. Future PACIFICA token discussed but supply, allocations and conversion ratio all unknown. Self-funded, no VC overhang.

Verdict: Winner for clarity today: neither. Both incomplete and speculative. Slight analytical edge to Lighter on revenue capture; slight structural edge to Pacifica on no VC baggage. Confidence: low.

3.8 UX, Performance and Reliability

Lighter: Custom zk rollup, Ethereum settlement, high-performance matching, but with at least one documented outage of about 4.5 hours caused by database growth under volatility; system stayed solvent and users were compensated.

Pacifica: Off-chain orderbook and matching engine delivering sub-10ms execution, with Solana programs handling custody and settlement; no major exploits reported but reliance on Solana liveness introduces structural fragility.

Verdict: For pure speed, Winner: Pacifica (medium conviction). For conservative infra and asset custody, Winner: Lighter (medium conviction).

3.9 Compliance, Geo and Access

Neither memo provides detailed information on KYC, geo-blocking or legal structure, beyond general notes like "no public legal entity clarity" for Pacifica and L2Beat governance description for Lighter.

Verdict: Not scored. This is a gap and would require fresh legal and product research per venue.

4. WHAT WOULD CHANGE THE RECOMMENDATIONS

Explicit conditions that would move this comparison meaningfully.

For Lighter

- **Clear LIGHT token design:** total supply, vesting, revenue share to token and LLP holders and hard constraints against wash trading.
- **Governance and decentralization upgrades:** longer upgrade timelocks, removal of instant upgrade paths, more transparent and possibly staked-based security council.
- **Oracle hardening:** on-chain verification of external signatures, more robust fallback logic and circuit constraints around oracle anomalies.
- **Sustained metrics:** OI, TVL and fee revenue after points Season 2 ends and after TGE.

For Pacifica

- **Full contract and program ID disclosure:** plus additional audits that cover the full on-chain surface, with clear follow-ups.
- **Clear, coherent PACIFICA token announcement:** including point conversion, allocations, supply, governance powers and any fee sharing.
- **Transparent Squads multisig configuration:** signer disclosure and live timelocks for upgrades and treasury actions.
- **Evidence of sticky demand:** daily volumes, OI and TVL stay strong after fee promos and points are tapered, indicating organic trader demand.

Conservative Institutional Stance

Until some of these conditions are met, the conservative institutional stance implied by this research is:

- **Lighter:** candidate for future core perp exposure once governance and token design are de-risked.
- **Pacifica:** watchlist, tactical Solana perps venue, with sizing capped until governance transparency and post-incentive traction are proven.

5. SUMMARY COMPARISON TABLE

Dimension	Lighter	Pacifica
Chain	Ethereum (zk rollup)	Solana L1
TVL	~\$1.23B	~\$40M
Open Interest	~\$1.7B	~\$50-60M
30d Volume	~\$298B	>\$1B daily
Composite Score	76/100	67/100
Token Status	No live token (Points)	No live token (Points)
Insurance Fund	LLP (explicit)	Treasury/Cold vault

Governance Stage	Stage 0 rollup	Team-controlled
Primary Use Case	Institutional, EVM	Solana native
Key Risk	Upgrade/Oracle	Governance opacity

FINAL VERDICT

Lighter is the default institutional and EVM choice – more absolute liquidity, explicit insurance mechanisms, and Ethereum security guarantees make it suitable for serious size and systematic strategies.

Pacifica is the tactical Solana native choice – CEX-like performance and ecosystem integration make it attractive for Solana-native traders, but thinner capital base and governance opacity limit institutional conviction.

Both remain in "research and watchlist" territory until token designs, governance structures, and post-incentive traction are clarified.

Not investment advice, research only.